

Attracting a mate

When the breeding season arrives, animals concentrate on the all-important task of finding a mate. For males, competition for partners can be fierce, and many species put all their energy into showing off or into fighting with rival males. Zebras bite and kick, while kangaroos trade kicks and punches, but many contests are set-piece rituals where the loser escapes unharmed. In some species, males gather at “showgrounds” called leks, where they compete for center stage and the chance to mate with the most females. Females rarely fight over males. Instead, they do the choosing. They look for partners that are strong and healthy, with the best territories, or with the most eye-catching displays.



Neck feathers are fluffed out during display

High jump

Little bustards live in open grassland, where they crouch down among the plants for protection. However, during the breeding season male birds gather at leks, where they stamp their feet and leap into the air. Attracted by these flamboyant displays, females come to choose the male that impresses them the most.

Battle for supremacy

On the edge of a waterhole, a plains zebra delivers a painful bite to a rival's neck. When males fight, a well-aimed kick is most dangerous, particularly if it lands on the opponent's legs—a lame zebra is soon picked off by predators. The strongest breeding males control a group, or harem, of up to six females. The harem stays together along with any young, even when they form part of a bigger herd.



Arching wall of bower up to 18 in (45 cm) high

The art of attraction

Male bowerbirds appeal to females by building bizarre structures called bowers, which contain hundreds of carefully arranged sticks. Here, a male great bowerbird is using shells to decorate a completed bower. His handiwork has already attracted a female, who is inspecting the bower from inside. After mating, the female flies away and builds herself a nest.

